freight to the French port of Le Havre. In reality, it took on the equipment and personnel of the military communications center to be set up in Cuba and the officers and soldiers who would operate it. The ship left Feodosia on August 11 in utmost secrecy: all shore leaves were canceled, a measure enforced by Captain Zozulia, a KGB officer assigned to the ship.[2]

On August 14, the ship's captain presented its false cargo declaration to the Turkish authorities, and the *Ilia Mechnikov* passed through the Bosporus without incident. But when the ship was already in the Mediterranean, heading toward Gibraltar, an emergency occurred that required the attention not only of the ship's captain but also of the accompanying KGB officer, Captain Zozulia. The emergency concerned the ship's mechanic, whose surname was Mazur. Soon after the *Ilia Mechnikov* left the Black Sea, Mazur began complaining of pain in his abdomen. The ship's doctor, named Zholkevsky, examined Mazur and diagnosed acute inflammation of the appendix. Mazur needed surgery, but Captain Zozulia could not send him ashore. While no one aboard knew the ship's true destination, its military cargo was top secret, and Mazur, like everyone else, knew that there was a discrepancy between the official cargo declaration and the actual freight it was carrying.

Zozulia's task was to make sure that no foreigner, especially the British authorities in Gibraltar, got access to Mazur and discovered through him what was going on. Zholkevsky and three of his colleagues, military doctors accompanying the military personnel, concluded that Mazur would die if he was not operated on. They decided to perform the surgery aboard ship. Zozulia, along with the ship's captain and his deputy, met with Mazur and convinced him to agree to the operation. He gave his consent.

The four doctors spent four hours in the ship's "Lenin room," a special compartment dedicated to the political indoctrination of the crew. The operation did not go well. The doctors failed to remove the inflamed appendix, closed the wound, and declared that Mazur needed another operation in a hospital. His condition was deteriorating, but landing him on shore was still not an option. They cabled Odesa for instructions and were advised to put Mazur on a Soviet ship heading back to the USSR.

Zozulia did as he was told: Mazur was transferred to the tanker *Iziaslav*, which they encountered sixty miles from Gibraltar. It had taken the *Ilia*